

Phyllis Schlafly

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By Arbora Johnson



Phyllis Schlafly, a conservative activist, commentator, and author, led a successful campaign against the ratification of the Equal Rights Amendment in the 1970s. She was an influential figure in conservative American politics and policymaking, arguing against feminism, abortion,

and gay rights, and was one of the first to tap into the conservative religious sentiment based on what she termed "family values."

Schlafly's influence on the Republican Party and American politics reverberates strongly today.

Phyllis McAlpin Stewart was born on August 15, 1924, in St. Louis, Missouri. She was the eldest child of John Bruce Stewart, a machinist and salesman, and Odile Stewart, a teacher and librarian. Schlafly's father was frequently unemployed during the Great Depression, leading her mother to return to work to help support the family, which also included Schlafly's younger sister.

Schlafly earned a scholarship to college after graduating first in her class from a Catholic high school. In 1944, she graduated from Washington University and went on to earn a Master's Degree in government from Radcliffe College at Harvard University in 1945. She worked on an assembly line at a munitions factory during World War II to pay for part of her college tuition.

After college, Schlafly went to work in Washington, D.C. for the conservative think tank American Enterprise Institute and on conservative political campaigns for members of Congress. She married lawyer (John) Fred Schlafly in 1949, and in 1957 the two were the primary authors of an influential paper for the American Bar Association entitled: "Report on Communist Tactics, Strategy, and